

SBNFA In Tower Training At Tahquitz Fire Lookout

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A few months back Kim and I went through two days worth of classroom training in order to become fire lookout volunteers with San Bernardino National Forest Association. Since then we've been struggling to find a free weekend day when we could schedule in tower with one of the trainers for our initial shift. Well, Saturday the 5th the stars aligned and we got our slot.

After a rather late night at a friend's 4th of July party (which involved fireworks and paramedics though there was actually no relation between the two) and making last minute preparations for the weekend we awoke a little before 3 am to start our day. After quick showers we grabbed out gear and started the 99 mile drive to the trailhead in Idyllwild.



By 6 am we found ourselves once again climbing the Devil's Slide Trail (last seen during the Cornell Peak backpack a few weeks back.) It was early enough we didn't have direct sunlight until we had gained a bit of altitude but it was still enough to make us sweat.

There were not too many other people on the trail which kind of surprised me. Southern California is suffering under a smoke cloud from the fires up north so maybe that dissuaded the usual crowds or maybe they all just got later starts than us.

We needed to be at the tower by 8:30 to start our shift so we were on the clock right from the start. With Kim not being a morning person it took a bit of encouragement to maintain the 2 mph pace.



This was the first look at the peak from the trail. The lookout is located near the highest point and can be seen from the full sized image on the Flickr site.

So after a brisk hike in of around 4.5 miles and 2,000 ft of gain we arrived around 8:10 am at the lookout itself. We were greeted by the tower leader Bob and Brad who was to be performing our training.



Among the lookouts in the San Bernardino Forest Tahquitz is rather unique in that it is 4 miles in from the nearest car accessible area. That means while some of the others have electricity and bathroom facilities we have bushes and whatever we can carry up. On the plus side we have our views up at 8800 ft.



This is the view from the tower looking back towards where we hiked up. Not too shabby.

The tower was a paid lookout position until 1993 at which point it was closed for 5 years until SBNFA reopened it as a volunteer post in 1998. It is all wood construction and actually used to have living quarters on the ground floor and an outhouse. These days the outhouse is a pile of foul smelling lumber and the living space below the tower is inaccessible storage though there is a plan to reclaim it when a sufficient work crew can make it up there.



To access the cab you climb a set of wooden stairs to a catwalk running all the way around a square window enclosed room. This is our working area. (Note the picture above is from last year when the tower was shuttered. I didn't take one from this angle this trip/)



There is a fully stocked desk area with everything from forest service safety manuals to our own organizations handbook to a leather bound journal which one of the hosts has apparently been keeping since starting in 2002



Next to the desk area is the bed. Barely large enough to fit 2 people (and only if they are really friendly) the usual procedure is to pull off the extra bed pad and put it on the floor if multiple people are staying overnight.



The sink used to be fed by the 100 gallon tank resting on top of the tower. Again this has not been used since the tower went out of paid service in 1993 but the plumbing is still there. Us volunteers all have to carry our water up or we pump it at a spring about a mile down from the tower.



This is the old stove and heater. Neither are safe to use anymore (it wouldn't do for the fire lookout to catch on fire after all, though it would be easy to call in the location) so they remain as antiques. The green Coleman stove on top of the old white stove is available for used by the lookout hosts.



The center of the cab is dominated by an Osborne Fire Finder. There's quite a bit of history to the devices but basically it has a map of the surrounding 20 miles (our area of responsibility) under the disc and rotates to allow us to determine a bearing to a smoke plum we see out one of the windows. From there we use the map to determine nearby landmarks and radio in a location and description of the sighting.





The metal hatch next to the desk can be pulled aside to see into the lower part of the tower. The plan is to restore this area but for now it just contains supplies.



Apparently the outhouse fell down a few years ago. Due to the fact the tower is located in a wilderness area it is a massive amount of paperwork to get a helicopter to drop

anything off. When the door of the lookout was forced open last year and had to be replaced it took about 2 and a half months to get everything cleared to have a helicopter just lower the door in.





Since Bob and Brad had stayed overnight Friday the tower was already open and in service when we arrived. Since this was our training session we went through the motions anyway on a special radio frequency used by all the towers. That included taking weather measurements, going in to service with dispatch down in San Bernardino, and radioing in a practice smoke report.

We are a volunteer position but officially we are unpaid employees of the forest service. We are in radio contact with dispatch in San Bernardino in order to go in and out of service, deliver weather reports, and report smoke sightings.

Sometime around 10 the visitors started arriving. We had several people who had never been up there before and we gave them the tour and pointed out visible landmarks in the distance. In the morning we could make out Palomar Observatory, Santiago Peak, and Baldy but by the time afternoon had rolled around the smoke had decreased our visibility a bit.

The visitors ranged from folks who would come up, look around, and take off to one rather lonely lady who must have hung around about 40 minutes chatting with us. I also did my usual duty as photo boy climbing around on rocks and taking group shots of the visitors with their cameras.

There was a slow spot in the middle of the day where there were no visitors and the lack of sleep really started to weigh on Kim and I but soon people started arriving again. Besides that slow period the day actual passed fairly quickly. We had access to

binoculars and could see down into Idyllwild or watch gliders catching updrafts around the ridges.



Our trainer Brad is also a volunteer with the Wilderness Rangers who do patrols in the non-state wilderness area of San Jacinto checking permits and generally helping people out. This is another program I'm interested in volunteering for so I was able to get quite a bit of information about that. Now I just need a bit more free time.

At 4:30 the stream of visitors had died off and we were told we were free to leave. Brad was staying up another night so while we reviewed the tower closing procedure again we didn't have to actually perform it. We left him our extra water and headed down.

The hike down is literally all down and so went quickly. As we drove through Idyllwild Kim and I stopped by our favorite Mexican food restaurant out there to celebrate being official. Strangely enough we actually ran into someone we knew. Claire, one of the fellow students during last year's Wilderness First Aid course.

By the time we arrived home sometime after 8 pm I was dead to the world and fell asleep at the first opportunity. Kim and I will be back on the same mountain next weekend for her O2 provisional though we'll be back on the northern end near where we stayed for the Cornell trip.

We haven't yet scheduled our August shift in the tower but both of us are looking forward to taking advantage of the overnight privilege they allow us volunteers.

As always, full sized images available at:

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157606011470802/>

- Matthew Hengst